

Crucial Conversation Prep Worksheet

Scenario Example: “The performance improvement plan is not fair.”



1. Lead with the Heart

Purpose: Begin from a place of empathy, genuine care, and shared goals. Reflect on your intent — the goal is to help the person grow and succeed.

Example Reflection: “I want to help the agent see that the PIP is not a punishment but a support plan to help them succeed.”

Prompts:

- What do I appreciate about this person or their effort recently?
- How might they be feeling about this situation?
- How can I show that I’m here to help, not to blame?

2. Define the Ideal Outcome

Purpose: Clearly visualize what “success” looks like after the conversation.

Example: “By the end of the discussion, I want them to feel heard, understand the reasons behind the PIP, and be open to collaborating on a plan that helps them meet expectations.”

3. Define the Negative Outcome to Avoid

Purpose: Identify what could go wrong if emotions or defensiveness take over.

Example: “I want to avoid the conversation turning into blame or arguments about fairness.”



4. Gather the Facts

Purpose: Enter the conversation equipped with accurate, objective information.

Example Notes:

- Attendance: 4 tardies, 2 unapproved absences (30 days).
 - QA average: 70% vs. team 85% (2 weeks).
 - Coaching sessions on June 12, 18, and 25 addressed the same areas.
 - The agent acknowledged understanding previously.
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5. Gain Buy-In After Presenting the Facts

Purpose: Invite the team member into the dialogue after sharing the facts to ensure mutual understanding and shared ownership.

Sample Questions:

- What are your thoughts about what I've shared?
 - Do you understand why we are implementing a PIP now?
 - From your point of view, what has contributed to the recent challenges?
 - Does any part of this feel unclear or unfair to you?
 - What support do you feel would make the biggest difference?
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6. Conversation Plan (Outline)

Example Flow and Dialogue:

1. Open with empathy and purpose

"I wanted to talk about your feedback that the PIP feels unfair. I understand this is stressful, and I want us to look at it together."

2. Acknowledge their feelings

"I appreciate you being honest — that tells me you care about your performance."

3. Present the facts calmly

"Here's what led to the PIP: a few missed attendance targets and a QA drop that we had coached on before."

4. Gain buy-in after presenting the facts

"Now that you've seen where the data comes from, how does that sit with you?"

5. Collaborate on the way forward

"Let's identify what support you need from me to meet your targets. The goal is not to penalize, but to help you succeed."

6. Reaffirm trust and partnership

"I believe in your ability to turn this around. Let's treat this plan as our shared roadmap to your success."

7. Reflection (After the Meeting)

- Did I lead with empathy and clarity?
- Did the conversation stay focused on growth and support?
- Did I invite the team member to share their perspective after presenting the facts?
- What went well?

- What could I improve next time?
